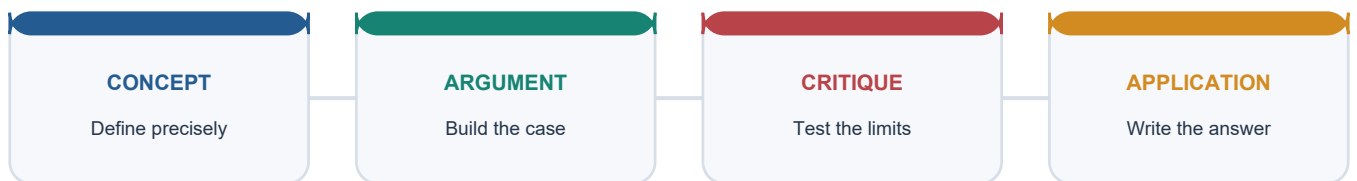


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Nature and Significance of Political Theory - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Nature and Significance of Political Theory - Solved Practice Workbook

Subject: Political Theory **Target stages:** UPSC Prelims and General Studies Mains only **Primary ownership:** GS-II conceptual foundations **Approval:** pending explicit user approval

WORKBOOK GUIDE

- Attempt Questions 1-24 as hard core diagnostics and Questions 25-32 as remedial traps.
- Record the reason for eliminating each wrong option before checking the solution.
- The key is a fixed A -> B -> C -> D rotation; cover it while attempting, because the rotation is a production standard and must never replace elimination reasoning.
- For Mains, write within the stated GS ceiling: 150 words for 10 marks and 250 words for 15 marks.
- No direct owned Prelims/GS Mains PYQ is verified for Topic 01; no question owned by another UPSC paper is imported or relabelled.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice design

- Questions 1-24 are hard core GS/Prelims diagnostics; Questions 25-32 are remedial close-option repairs.
- Formats are deliberately varied: definition control, multi-statement, sequence, matching, chronology, elimination, application, evidence and inference.
- The correct option rotates strictly A -> B -> C -> D, repeated eight times across the 32 questions, giving 8 A, 8 B, 8 C and 8 D.
- Because the key is a fixed rotation, it carries no diagnostic value: correct and distractor options are matched for length and register, so an answer can only be found by reasoning about content.
- Each of the 128 options carries its own explanation and each question closes with a distinct examiner trap.

MCQ 1

Which statement most accurately defines political theory in Gauba's opening formulation?

- A. Systematic knowledge of political phenomena, including factual and evaluative inquiry.
- B. A specialised study of constitutional offices and their legal powers.
- C. A normative blueprint for an ideal state independent of political facts.
- D. A strategy by which political groups justify an existing distribution of power.

Answer: A

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A is the source-grounded definition and preserves the empirical-logical-evaluative range.
- **B:** B narrows the field to formal institutions, while the chapter includes behaviour, concepts and values.
- **C:** C reduces theory to ideal construction, ignoring science, criticism and concept clarification.
- **D:** D describes ideology's interested justificatory role rather than political theory as a whole.

Examiner trap: Treating the word 'theory' as either an institutional manual or a utopian plan.

MCQ 2

Consider the following statements: 1. An empirical statement rests on observation. 2. A logical statement rests on reasoning. 3. An evaluative statement judges what is right or desirable. Which are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 1, 2 and 3
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1 and 3 only

Answer: B

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A wrongly excludes evaluative judgment from the scope of political theory.
- **B:** B correctly reproduces all three statement-types in the chapter.
- **C:** C wrongly omits the observation-based empirical category.
- **D:** D wrongly omits logical or inferential statements.

Examiner trap: Assuming that because evaluative claims are not experimentally verified, they are absent from theory.

MCQ 3

The most useful distinction drawn by D. D. Raphael for Political Theory is that:

- A. science studies public institutions whereas philosophy studies private morality.
- B. science predicts the future whereas philosophy records the past.
- C. science seeks explanation whereas philosophy seeks justification.
- D. science is value-laden whereas philosophy is necessarily value-neutral.

Answer: C

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A invents a public-private division between the disciplines that Raphael does not make.
- **B:** B confuses method with temporal subject matter.
- **C:** C states Raphael's explanation-versus-justification criterion.
- **D:** D reverses the usual value-neutrality claim and misstates both fields.

Examiner trap: Choosing a broad science/philosophy contrast instead of Raphael's precise functional test.

MCQ 4

Andrew Hacker, whom Gauba follows here, insists that political theory be kept distinct from ideology. Which feature marks that distinction most clearly?

- A. Theory examines only values and ultimate ends, whereas ideology confines itself to recording observed facts about political behaviour.
- B. Theory belongs to democratic orders, whereas ideology appears only under authoritarian rule.
- C. Theory avoids collective purposes, whereas ideology alone discusses goals for political action.
- D. Theory tests claims through evidence and criticism; ideology justifies a preferred distribution of power.

Answer: D

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A inverts both sides: theory includes empirical, logical and evaluative inquiry, while ideology is an interested justification rather than a fact-recording exercise.
- **B:** B is false because ideology may operate in any political order.

- **C:** C is false because political theory explicitly examines collective ends.
- **D:** D captures Hacker's test: a theorist without a personal stake reasons dispassionately, whereas the ideologue is an interested party defending or attacking a system of power.

Examiner trap: Using subject matter to separate theory and ideology when the decisive issue is standpoint and testing.

MCQ 5

Andrew Hacker's 'double role' of the political theorist implies that:

- A. factual understanding and reflection on political goals must inform one another.
- B. political philosophy should absorb political science completely.
- C. a theorist should alternate between academic and party-political employment.
- D. scientific findings become valid only after ideological endorsement.

Answer: A

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A correctly links the scientist's grasp of facts with the philosopher's concern for goals.
- **B:** B destroys the complementarity Hacker defends.
- **C:** C literalises 'double role' into an occupational claim.
- **D:** D subordinates inquiry to ideology, the opposite of Hacker's warning.

Examiner trap: Reading 'part scientist and part philosopher' as two jobs rather than two intellectual tasks.

MCQ 6

Which combination best states the principal functions of political theory in Gauba's conclusion?

- A. Observation, legislation and adjudication.
- B. Description, criticism and reconstruction.
- C. Prediction, propaganda and mobilisation.
- D. Classification, administration and enforcement.

Answer: B

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A mixes a method with functions of state organs.
- **B:** B is the chapter's express three-function formulation: science specialises in description, philosophy in criticism and reconstruction.
- **C:** C wrongly treats propaganda as a theoretical function.
- **D:** D substitutes administrative activities for intellectual functions.

Examiner trap: Confusing the functions of political theory with functions of government.

MCQ 7

Which sequence most closely follows Gauba's account of scientific inquiry in politics?

- A. Prescription -> observation -> explanation -> generalisation -> verification.
- B. Explanation -> evaluation -> observation -> reconstruction.
- C. Observation -> generalisation -> explanation -> prediction and prescription.
- D. Generalisation -> ideology -> prediction -> verification.

Answer: C

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A begins with prescription before any evidence, then appends verification to a rule that has not yet been formed, reversing the chapter's stated order.
- **B:** B inserts evaluation and reconstruction into the scientific sequence.
- **C:** C reproduces the stated order from observation to usable anticipation and advice.
- **D:** D wrongly makes ideology a scientific stage.

Examiner trap: Starting with policy prescription instead of grounding it in observation and explanation.

MCQ 8

Post-behaviouralism is best understood as:

- A. a rejection of systematic observation in favour of a return to classical texts and the history of political ideas.
- B. a claim that all evaluative judgments are scientifically verifiable.
- C. a defence of political neutrality from every public crisis.
- D. a demand for relevance and values while retaining scientific inquiry into facts.

Answer: D

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A mistakes a correction of scientism for the very traditionalism Easton had attacked in 1953.
- **B:** B collapses the distinction between empirical verification and normative reasoning.
- **C:** C reverses the post-behavioural demand for engagement with urgent problems.
- **D:** D captures Easton's 1969 move from pure to socially relevant applied inquiry.

Examiner trap: Equating the restoration of values with abandonment of scientific method.

MCQ 9

Which statement correctly relates Easton's 1953 and 1969 positions?

- A. The 1953 critique prioritised causal theory; the 1969 turn restored values and relevance while retaining science.
- B. Both positions rejected causal explanation and favoured traditional speculation as the proper method.
- C. The 1953 position defended classical values and historical scholarship, while the 1969 position demanded strict methodological neutrality.
- D. The 1969 position repeated the 1953 programme without restoring either values or public relevance.

Answer: A

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A accurately separates The Political System (1953) from the 1969 American Political Science Association presidential address that converted political science from a pure to an applied science.
- **B:** B contradicts Easton's early demand for causal theory.
- **C:** C reverses both interventions: 1953 attacked classicism and 1969 abandoned strict neutrality.
- **D:** D erases the value-and-relevance correction central to post-behaviouralism.

Examiner trap: Merging Easton's two positions because the same thinker is involved.

MCQ 10

Which statement most accurately captures Alfred Cobban's 1953 decline thesis in 'The Decline of Political Theory'?

- A. He claimed that American liberal democracy had completed the search for the good society.
- B. He diagnosed decline in both capitalist and communist systems but retained the need for criteria of judgment.
- C. He argued that electoral statistics and survey data should replace every remaining form of normative political philosophy.
- D. He identified revival with positivist social science and the exclusion of evaluative judgment.

Answer: B

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A is Lipset's 1960 Political Man claim about the United States, not Cobban's cross-system diagnosis.
- **B:** B states Cobban's two-sided position: libertarian democracy produced no theorist of democracy and communist rule rested on party oligarchy, yet political science must still evolve criteria of judgment.
- **C:** C invents a statistical remedy; Cobban blamed logical positivism's facts-only focus and still asked for criteria of judgment.
- **D:** D reverses him, since he treated positivist value-exclusion as a cause of decline, not a cure.

Examiner trap: Swapping Cobban's cross-system diagnosis with Lipset's American good-society thesis.

MCQ 11

Seymour Martin Lipset's 'good society' claim should be treated as:

- A. A universal proof that ideological conflict had ended wherever electoral democracy existed.
- B. A defence of communist party organisation as the final and universally valid political form.
- C. A bounded mid-century claim about United States liberal democracy, not a universal verdict.
- D. A post-behavioural demand to restore values in direct response to an immediate political crisis.

Answer: C

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A turns a bounded argument into an indefensible universal law.
- **B:** B has no relation to Lipset's stated position.
- **C:** C preserves the historical and geographical qualification required by the source.
- **D:** D describes Easton's later turn rather than Lipset's thesis.

Examiner trap: Removing the United States and mid-century context from Lipset's claim.

MCQ 12

Leo Strauss's objection to positivist political science is most accurately expressed as:

- A. All empirical research is impossible because political facts are necessarily ideological.
- B. Political philosophy should avoid judgments about justice, tyranny and the quality of regimes.
- C. Scientific method belongs to economics and the natural sciences but has no valid political use.
- D. Value-neutrality flattens normative distinctions and cannot adequately rank tyranny below justice.

Answer: D

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A converts a critique of scientism into wholesale scepticism about facts.
- **B:** B states the opposite of Strauss's recovery of normative judgment.
- **C:** C invents a disciplinary boundary absent from the argument.
- **D:** D captures the hierarchy-of-values objection.

Examiner trap: Reading Strauss as anti-evidence rather than anti-reductionist.

MCQ 13

For Dante Germino, revival of political theory centrally required:

- A. Reviving political philosophy as inquiry into right order, with detachment distinct from ethical neutrality.
- B. Accepting inherited ideologies as valid expressions of social experience without testing their claims.
- C. Restricting valid political inquiry to observable behaviour, measurement and sense-experience.
- D. Closing debate over perennial political problems once a stable constitutional order is achieved.

Answer: A

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A states Germino's conception of revival and critical engagement.
- **B:** B confuses philosophy with untested ideology.
- **C:** C describes the reductionism Germino opposes.
- **D:** D reverses his insistence that perennial problems remain.

Examiner trap: Treating scholarly detachment as moral indifference.

MCQ 14

Herbert Marcuse's warning about a natural-science style political inquiry is that it may:

- A. Make political concepts too precise for meaningful democratic disagreement and public debate.
- B. Translate critique into measurable adjustment and thereby stabilise the existing political order.
- C. Prevent every quantitative measurement of voting, participation and institutional performance.
- D. Eliminate all legitimate administrative uses of evidence gathered by the social sciences.

Answer: B

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A is not his objection; precision itself is not the problem.
- **B:** B captures the risk that measurement becomes social control rather than critical inquiry.
- **C:** C is false because his example assumes participation is being measured.
- **D:** D is stronger than the argument and rejects legitimate empirical work.

Examiner trap: Mistaking a warning about reductionism for a ban on quantitative research.

MCQ 15

Gauba narrows 'politics' from the comprehensive Greek polis, which covered every activity aimed at the good life, to the modern public sphere. Which application best respects the resulting public-private distinction?

- A. Every family choice is automatically political and should therefore be regulated by the state.
- B. Only decisions formally enacted by Parliament can count as political decisions or processes.
- C. A usually private relation may become political when power, rights or public regulation are involved.
- D. Culture and education remain permanently outside political analysis, even when public order is involved.

Answer: C

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A erases the analytical distinction and restores the undifferentiated polis Gauba says modern usage abandoned.
- **B:** B narrows politics to one institution, excluding cabinet decisions, party activity and people's movements.

- **C:** C matches Gauba's rule that faith, education, art and culture enter politics only when regulation is needed for public order and safety, while allowing a reasoned feminist qualification.
- **D:** D ignores the explicit public-order and safety qualification attached to the modern narrowing.

Examiner trap: Treating public and private as fixed natural domains rather than an analytical boundary.

MCQ 16

Why does the strong claim that political theory 'should be value-free' face an internal difficulty?

- A. Every empirical political claim is necessarily false because observation is always incomplete.
- B. Logical reasoning becomes possible only after a political ideology supplies its first premises.
- C. Political philosophy can experimentally verify every contested value in the same manner as a fact.
- D. Choosing to exclude evaluation is itself a normative decision about what should count as valid inquiry.

Answer: D

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A is an absurd overcorrection; empirical claims may be well supported.
- **B:** B wrongly makes logic dependent on ideology.
- **C:** C confuses reasoned justification with experimental verification.
- **D:** D identifies the self-referential problem in the strong value-free thesis.

Examiner trap: Attacking value-neutrality by denying facts instead of exposing its hidden value premise.

MCQ 17

A welfare scheme shows high coverage but excludes a vulnerable group from consultation. Political theory would most appropriately:

- A. Combine the empirical result with questions about fairness, affected voice and legitimate justification.
- B. Reject the coverage evidence because quantitative findings cannot contribute to political judgment.
- C. Treat electoral approval as conclusive proof that every exclusion within the scheme is just.
- D. Classify the allocation as private morality because public authority is not relevant to welfare delivery.

Answer: A

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A applies the facts-plus-values framework to a GS-II governance problem.
- **B:** B discards useful empirical evidence and repeats the error of evidence-free normativity.
- **C:** C confuses majority support with complete normative legitimacy.
- **D:** D ignores the public allocation and authority involved.

Examiner trap: Believing that a favourable performance indicator settles the justice of a policy.

MCQ 18

Which pair is correctly classified?

- A. 'The policy is fair' - empirical; 'turnout rose' - evaluative.
- B. One claim observes a turnout change; the other judges whether the reform is just.
- C. 'The conclusion follows from the premises' - empirical; 'inflation rose' - logical.
- D. 'Justice requires equality' - empirical; 'two claims are inconsistent' - evaluative.

Answer: B

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A reverses observation and value judgment.
- **B:** B correctly distinguishes an observable claim from a judgment about justice.
- **C:** C confuses logical validity with observed economic change.
- **D:** D treats a normative proposition as observation and a logical relation as evaluation.

Examiner trap: Classifying a sentence by political importance rather than by the kind of claim it makes.

MCQ 19

The question 'What is a good society?' belongs primarily to political philosophy because it asks:

- A. how frequently citizens participate in elections.
- B. which measurable variables correlate most strongly with observed political violence.
- C. which ends and principles can be justified for collective life.
- D. how accurately a survey predicts voting behaviour.

Answer: C

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A is an empirical measurement question.
- **B:** B is a causal-explanatory question that political science answers by correlation, not justification.
- **C:** C correctly identifies the justificatory inquiry into political ends.
- **D:** D concerns empirical prediction and research design.

Examiner trap: Choosing any question about society rather than identifying the evaluative demand.

MCQ 20

Concept clarification contributes to political theory chiefly by:

- A. fixing one ideological definition permanently so rival schools can no longer dispute the concept.
- B. separating political language completely from every ordinary-language use of the same expression.
- C. replacing argument about contested concepts with the shortest available dictionary definition.
- D. analysing the elements of a concept, synthesising its relations and improving its use.

Answer: D

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A turns clarification into ideological closure, which is the opposite of a dialogue between rival users.
- **B:** B ignores Wolin's observation that 'authority of the father', 'of the church' and 'of Parliament' run in parallel, which is exactly why technical meaning must be fixed rather than severed.
- **C:** C reduces philosophical work to lexical reporting and leaves demagogues free to exploit vague terms.
- **D:** D captures Raphael's three purposes: analysis (sovereignty as supreme legal authority), synthesis (a right implies an obligation) and improvement (restricting sovereignty to legal authority).

Examiner trap: Assuming clarification eliminates disagreement instead of making its grounds visible.

MCQ 21

Which statement best connects description, criticism and reconstruction?

- A. Theory describes political reality, criticises defects and reconstructs defensible alternatives.
- B. Description alone determines which political order is just and therefore makes criticism unnecessary.
- C. Criticism becomes valid only after a proposed reconstruction has already been implemented successfully.
- D. Reconstruction should proceed without understanding existing institutions, behaviour or consequences.

Answer: A

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A states the complementary three-function sequence.
- **B:** B makes an evaluative conclusion follow mechanically from facts.
- **C:** C reverses the logical order of assessment and proposed change.
- **D:** D makes reform indifferent to actual conditions.

Examiner trap: Treating the three functions as rival schools rather than connected tasks.

MCQ 22

Which case most clearly illustrates ideology rather than political theory?

- A. A researcher revises a political claim after serious evidence contradicts its original assumptions.
- B. A movement treats its preferred power distribution as unquestionable and uses concepts to legitimise it.
- C. A philosopher compares rival meanings of liberty and explains the implications of each meaning.
- D. A scholar distinguishes causal explanation from normative justification within a public-policy dispute.

Answer: B

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A displays revisability characteristic of inquiry.
- **B:** B shows interested justification protected from validity-testing.
- **C:** C is concept clarification within political philosophy.
- **D:** D is analytical distinction-making, not ideological closure.

Examiner trap: Calling every politically committed argument ideological even when it remains open to criticism.

MCQ 23

Which thinker-position pair is incorrectly matched?

- A. Wolin - the political concerns what is common to the community.
- B. Catlin - political theory includes political science and political philosophy.
- C. Held - political science should suspend values permanently.
- D. Hacker - factual knowledge and political goals must be related.

Answer: C

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A is a correct source-grounded pairing.
- **B:** B is a correct formulation of Catlin's division.
- **C:** C is incorrect: Held warns against abandoning systematic theory to ignorance or will to power.
- **D:** D accurately states Hacker's double-role thesis.

Examiner trap: Attaching Easton's early behavioural prescription to Held.

MCQ 24

Arrange the following contributions to the decline-and-revival debate in correct chronological order: 1. Alfred Cobban, 'The Decline of Political Theory'. 2. Seymour Martin Lipset, Political Man: The Social Bases of Politics. 3. Dante Germino, Beyond Ideology: The Revival of Political Theory. 4. David Easton's post-behavioural presidential address.

- A. 2-1-4-3
- B. 1-3-2-4
- C. 3-1-2-4
- D. 1-2-3-4

Answer: D

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A puts Lipset's 1960 book before Cobban's 1953 paper and Germino's 1967 book after 1969.
- **B:** B places Germino's 1967 revival argument before Lipset's 1960 good-society claim.
- **C:** C opens with Germino's 1967 book, fourteen years after Cobban's 1953 paper.
- **D:** D is correct: Cobban 1953, Lipset 1960, Germino 1967 and Easton's 1969 address.

Examiner trap: Recalling the thinkers but not the publication years that fix the sequence of the debate.

MCQ 25 - REMEDIAL

Which is the most accurate statement about the scope of Political Theory in this repository?

- A. It supplies GS/Prelims concepts; direct constitutional and institutional facts remain with their GS owners.
- B. It replaces detailed Polity preparation because conceptual language is sufficient for constitutional questions.
- C. It owns questions from every UPSC paper whenever the same concepts or thinkers appear in the stem.
- D. It converts questions owned by another UPSC paper into Political Theory questions for practice.

Answer: A

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A states the required GS-only ownership boundary.
- **B:** B confuses conceptual foundations with direct constitutional coverage.
- **C:** C wrongly turns conceptual overlap into ownership of every UPSC paper.
- **D:** D violates verified PYQ ownership and classification.

Examiner trap: Mistaking conceptual usefulness across papers for ownership of those papers.

MCQ 26 - REMEDIAL

A learner says, 'Political theory is just ideology because both defend values.' What is the best repair?

- A. Correct, because every evaluative claim is ideological whenever it concerns public values or power.
- B. Incorrect: theory tests value claims through reasons and revision; ideology protects an interested power position.
- C. Correct, provided the ideology supports democratic procedures, uses constitutional vocabulary and commands settled majority assent.
- D. Incorrect only because ideology is empirical, whereas political theory is exclusively evaluative.

Answer: B

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A collapses reasoned evaluation into partisan justification.
- **B:** B states the analytical distinction while allowing that theory can itself become ideological.

- **C:** C makes democratic content and popular support substitutes for critical testing, which is exactly the closure Gauba identifies as ideological.
- **D:** D misclassifies ideology as merely empirical.

Examiner trap: Using the presence of values, rather than openness to criticism, as the deciding test.

MCQ 27 - REMEDIAL

A learner says, 'Post-behaviouralism restored values, so it rejected scientific standards.' Which correction is strongest?

- A. It rejected prediction alone but retained every other feature of strict behavioural value-neutrality.
- B. It returned political theory exclusively to classical ideal-state construction and textual commentary.
- C. It restored values and relevance while retaining scientific investigation of political facts.
- D. It treated all disputed political values as experimentally proven by the methods of natural science.

Answer: C

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A invents a selective rejection not stated in the source.
- **B:** B reduces political philosophy to ideal blueprints.
- **C:** C gives the exact correction required by Easton's 1969 turn.
- **D:** D confuses normative reasoning with empirical verification.

Examiner trap: Reading 'post-' as total abandonment rather than critical revision.

MCQ 28 - REMEDIAL

A learner writes, 'Political theory died in the 1950s and returned in the 1970s.' Which replacement is most defensible?

- A. The decline was mainly a temporary shortage of publications by major political philosophers.
- B. Political science disappeared as an academic discipline until John Rawls single-handedly recreated it through a theory of justice.
- C. Capitalist and communist states legally prohibited every form of systematic political reflection.
- D. A traditional mode lost authority; behavioural and normative corrections transformed rather than resurrected theory.

Answer: D

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A trivialises a methodological and normative debate.
- **B:** B fabricates a disappearance and gives Rawls a founding role the chapter never assigns him.
- **C:** C overstates Cobban's diagnosis into a universal legal claim.
- **D:** D preserves chronology, competing diagnoses and the mode-versus-enterprise distinction.

Examiner trap: Turning a contested intellectual shift into a literal disappearance-and-return event.

MCQ 29 - REMEDIAL

Which GS answer move best demonstrates claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification?

- A. Political theory integrates explanation and justification; Raphael's distinction shows why policy data cannot alone settle legitimacy.
- B. Political theory combines facts and values, so empirical and normative claims need no separate standards.
- C. Raphael discussed philosophy and Easton discussed science, so citing both names in the introduction is by itself enough to prove the argument.
- D. Political theory is important because major thinkers support it, which is sufficient evidence of usefulness.

Answer: A

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A contains the claim, named evidence, inference and limiting qualification.
- **B:** B states a claim but supplies neither named evidence nor qualification.
- **C:** C name-drops two thinkers without stating what their propositions establish or where they stop.
- **D:** D offers assertion and vague authority without analytical linkage.

Examiner trap: Mistaking a list of thinkers for evidence-linked analysis.

MCQ 30 - REMEDIAL

Which statement best captures the final means-ends synthesis?

- A. Political philosophy selects efficient means, while political science defines the ultimate ends of politics.
- B. Science clarifies political facts and means; political philosophy judges values and collective ends.
- C. Science and philosophy use identical methods and should therefore be merged into one undifferentiated inquiry.
- D. Political ends are private preferences and should remain outside public reasoning and justification.

Answer: B

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A reverses the chapter's division of labour.
- **B:** B states Gauba's concluding complementarity formula.
- **C:** C ignores their distinct standards and methods.
- **D:** D reproduces the value-exclusion position the chapter rejects.

Examiner trap: Remembering complementarity but reversing which branch handles means and ends.

MCQ 31 - REMEDIAL

In a Prelims-style close-option question, which proposition should be eliminated first?

- A. Evaluative claims require public reasons rather than sense-observation alone.
- B. Political philosophy includes criticism and concept clarification.
- C. Political Theory owns a separate UPSC paper in this repository.
- D. Behaviouralism strengthened attention to actual political behaviour.

Answer: C

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A is consistent with the chapter's defence of evaluative reasoning.
- **B:** B is Raphael's expanded account of philosophy.
- **C:** C violates the repository's explicit GS/Prelims classification.
- **D:** D identifies behaviouralism's genuine contribution.

Examiner trap: Allowing the philosophical character of some concepts to become a separate-paper ownership claim.

MCQ 32 - REMEDIAL

Which conclusion is best suited to a GS-II answer using Political Theory?

- A. The conceptual lens should replace constitutional provisions, institutional evidence and implementation facts.
- B. Normative theory is sufficient even when its assumptions conflict with verified evidence and consequences.
- C. Empirical success proves democratic legitimacy without any further argument about rights or public reason.
- D. A sound GS judgment joins verified consequences with public reasons about rights, fairness and legitimacy.

Answer: D

Option-by-option explanation

- **A:** A breaches the ownership boundary and weakens the answer.
- **B:** B permits evidence-free prescription.
- **C:** C treats an empirical indicator as a complete normative verdict.
- **D:** D applies the integrated framework while preserving direct-owner evidence.

Examiner trap: Using conceptual enrichment as a substitute for the factual core of a GS answer.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED UPSC PRELIMS / GS MAINS PYQ STATUS

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ORIGINAL GS MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original GS Mains Model 1 - 10 marks

Question: Explain why political theory cannot be reduced either to empirical political science or to normative political philosophy. Answer in 150 words.

Demand decode: 'Explain' asks for a reasoned account rather than a debate. Set out the two reductions separately, defeat each with a named proposition, and close on the integration that survives both objections. Listing thinkers without refuting both reductions under-answers the directive.

Model answer (136 words):

Political theory is systematic knowledge of political phenomena. It cannot be reduced to political science because public choices also require judgments about justice and legitimate ends; nor can it be reduced to philosophy because prescriptions must understand institutions, behaviour and consequences. D. D. Raphael clarifies the division: science seeks explanation, while philosophy seeks justification. Thus, observation may explain why riots occur, but it cannot by itself decide which restrictions are fair. Conversely, a moral ideal unsupported by facts may be infeasible or harmful. Andrew Hacker's claim that every political scientist is partly scientist and partly philosopher captures this interdependence. The synthesis does not erase standards: empirical claims remain answerable to evidence, while evaluative claims require coherent public reasons. Political theory is therefore a disciplined bridge-science clarifies facts and means; philosophy clarifies concepts and judges ends.

Why this earns marks: It refuses both reductions in turn, anchors each refusal in a named proposition from Raphael and Hacker, and closes on the means-and-ends formula instead of a general tribute to the subject.

Original GS Mains Model 2 - 10 marks

Question: Distinguish political theory from ideology and explain why the distinction matters. Answer in 150 words.

Demand decode: Two directives are joined. 'Distinguish' requires one decisive criterion rather than a list of differences, and 'explain why it matters' requires a stated consequence. The criterion is standpoint and openness to testing; the consequence is that identical vocabulary can illuminate or conceal power.

Model answer (143 words):

Political theory and ideology both use concepts such as liberty, equality and order, but they differ in intellectual posture. In Gauba's account, theory submits claims to evidence, logic, criticism and revision; ideology defends or challenges a distribution of power from an interested standpoint and often treats its premises as settled. The distinction matters because identical vocabulary can either illuminate politics or conceal domination. For example, a theory of property must test its effects and justificatory principles, whereas an ideology may present one property regime as self-evidently just. Yet the contrast is not absolute: theorists have social locations and theory can become ideological when it hides assumptions or ignores counter-evidence. The practical safeguard is transparent premises, reasoned dialogue and revisability. Thus, political theory is not value-free, but it remains different from ideology because it treats even its own values as open to critical justification.

Why this earns marks: It supplies a single decisive criterion, illustrates it with rival property regimes, and then concedes that theory itself can become ideological - the qualification that turns a definition into an argument.

Original GS Mains Model 3 - 10 marks

Question: How do concept clarification and reasoned disagreement explain the significance of political theory? Answer in 150 words.

Demand decode: 'How' demands a mechanism, not an assertion of importance. Show the three clarification operations, then show precisely what clarification achieves and what it cannot achieve. Significance must be derived from the mechanism rather than announced.

Model answer (137 words):

Political concepts are powerful precisely because they are general and contested. Gauba, drawing on D. D. Raphael, treats clarification as analysis of a concept's elements, synthesis of its relations and improvement of its use. This matters because words such as liberty, authority, equality and democracy can otherwise become slogans through which demagogues conceal weak arguments. Clarification does not compel agreement; it reveals what the disagreement is about. Andrew Hacker's image of political theory as a continuing conversation adds the democratic function: rival positions expose their premises, recognise strengths and weaknesses and remain open to persuasion. The limitation is that shared definitions do not remove conflicts of interest or values. Nevertheless, precise concepts make those conflicts more honest and peaceful. Political theory therefore contributes not only knowledge but also a public ethic of reason-giving, mutual respect and toleration.

Why this earns marks: It moves from Raphael's analysis-synthesis-improvement to the democratic function Hacker describes, and it states the limit: clarification makes disagreement precise without dissolving conflicts of interest.

Original GS Mains Model 4 - 15 marks

Question: Examine the claim that the decline of political theory was the decline of one mode of inquiry rather than the disappearance of theory. Answer in 250 words.

Demand decode: 'Examine' requires testing a stated proposition. Separate the three decline claims, weigh the revival evidence against them, and deliver a verdict that accepts, rejects or reformulates the claim. Narrating the debate without adjudicating it under-answers the directive.

Model answer (232 words):

The mid-twentieth-century decline thesis is persuasive only if 'decline' refers to a traditional mode of political theorising, not to the disappearance of systematic reflection on politics. David Easton's 1953 critique targeted speculation, dependence on classic texts and weak causal tools; his behavioural remedy prioritised observable conduct and explanatory theory. Alfred Cobban diagnosed marginalisation under both capitalist and communist systems, yet still insisted that politics required criteria of judgment beyond narrow social-science method. Seymour

Martin Lipset made a different, contextual claim: United States liberal democracy had approximated the good society, apparently narrowing the normative search. These arguments weakened classical, historical and openly evaluative theory, but they did not remove theoretical assumptions about relevance, evidence or desirable order. The strongest counter-evidence came from the revival. Strauss argued that value-neutral inquiry could not rank tyranny below justice. Germino recovered political philosophy as critical inquiry into right order, while Marcuse warned that measurement could normalise domination. Most decisively, Easton's 1969 post-behavioural turn restored relevance and values without abandoning scientific inquiry. The decline thesis therefore identifies a real methodological correction: theory had to become more empirical and contemporary. It fails, however, as a death certificate. Political inquiry continued to interpret concepts and choose ends even when it claimed neutrality. The better verdict is transformation: an insufficiently empirical mode declined, a facts-only remedy proved incomplete, and political theory revived as a more self-conscious integration of explanation and justification.

Why this earns marks: It separates Easton, Cobban and Lipset instead of merging them, uses Easton's own 1969 reversal as decisive internal counter-evidence, and reformulates the claim as transformation rather than death.

Original GS Mains Model 5 - 15 marks

Question: Discuss the contribution of behaviouralism and post-behaviouralism to the development of political theory. Answer in 250 words.

Demand decode: 'Discuss' requires balanced coverage of both movements plus a linking judgment. Each movement needs a stated contribution and a stated limit; treating post-behaviouralism only as a rejection of behaviouralism misses the continuity being tested.

Model answer (219 words):

Behaviouralism and post-behaviouralism contributed successive corrections to political theory. Behaviouralism redirected inquiry from formal institutions and inherited texts towards actual political behaviour. In Gauba's reconstruction, Easton's 1953 programme demanded observation, comparison, causal theory and closer engagement with other social sciences. Its durable contribution was methodological discipline: political claims had to be tested against evidence rather than protected by tradition. Its limitation followed from its strongest ambition. By suspending the quest for values, behaviouralism could explain conduct and consequences but could not decide which political ends deserved pursuit. Strauss's objection exposes the problem: a method that refuses qualitative judgment cannot adequately distinguish tyranny from justice. Marcuse adds that measurement may become administrative adjustment and stabilise the status quo. Post-behaviouralism, associated with Easton's 1969 turn, answered this failure by demanding relevance, action and responsiveness to social crisis while retaining scientific investigation of facts. Germino's distinction between scholarly detachment and ethical neutrality explains the new balance: inquiry need not become partisan merely because it acknowledges normative responsibility. The post-behavioural contribution is therefore not a return to unsupported moralism. It preserves behaviouralism's empirical gains and reconnects them with criticism, public purpose and justified ends. Together, the two movements transformed political theory from either textual speculation or narrow scientism into a plural discipline in which evidence constrains claims and normative argument evaluates their significance.

Why this earns marks: It credits behaviouralism with methodological discipline before naming its value-blindness, uses Strauss and Marcuse as the objections, and shows post-behaviouralism preserving the empirical gain.

Original GS Mains Model 6 - 15 marks

Question: Critically analyse the continuing significance of political theory for General Studies governance answers. Answer in 250 words.

Demand decode: 'Critically analyse' requires the case for, the strongest case against, and a reasoned position. The counter-case is abstraction and ideological drift, and the answer must also respect the ownership boundary with Polity and Governance.

Model answer (206 words):

Political theory strengthens General Studies answers by supplying the concepts and standards through which governance facts become political analysis. Its first contribution is clarification. Raphael's explanation-justification distinction prevents a candidate from treating administrative performance as proof of legitimacy. Coverage, speed or

compliance are empirical achievements; fairness, dignity and voice require additional reasons. Second, theory exposes hidden power. Wolin's common-sphere idea identifies authoritative collective decisions, while feminist criticism qualifies any rigid public-private boundary by showing that informal domination may have public consequences. Third, theory enables criticism and reconstruction. Held's warning against leaving politics to ignorance, self-interest or will to power explains why institutions must be assessed against defensible ends, not described mechanically. The strongest objection is that theoretical language can become abstract or ideological. That risk is real when concepts replace constitutional provisions, current evidence or implementation detail. The answer is disciplined use, not exclusion: make a claim, attach a named proposition or verified Indian example, explain what it proves, and state the limit. Political Theory in this repository therefore remains a GS/Prelims foundation, primarily for GS-II; it does not own questions from other UPSC papers or substitute for Polity and Governance facts. Properly used, it converts data into judgment while keeping judgment accountable to evidence.

Why this earns marks: It gives three distinct contributions with named anchors, states the abstraction objection at full strength, and resolves it with a rule of disciplined use plus an explicit ownership boundary.
